75 per cent, which is bloody hard work but manageable, and Broady wouldn't be trying to prove himself too often. Emerging bowlers such as Chris Woakes or Mark Wood would seek to make a personal statement in every session.

As captain, I understood and applauded that, but as a batsman, seeking rhythm in England in early summer, where nets are not as flat as they are on the subcontinent, the challenge became claustrophobic. I'd maintain my performance level, operating at about 98 per cent of my capacity over three twenty-minute sessions, often against lads I'd never seen before, but it became wearing.

I consulted with Mark Bawden, England's team psychologist, about how I could deal better with the dilemma. We spoke about having a very clear focus, a specific task to work through before a particular match, but eventually the dials just went round and round without registering. I made a conscious effort to sustain my intensity, but it became more of a chore.

Once instinct tells you the end is near, lethargy seeps into the system like slurry in a watercourse. Most people can't detect the difference, but long-term teammates have a sixth sense for mood swings. I'd played with Broady for eleven years; one throwaway line after a net session early in that final series against India told me he knew, deep down, what I was fighting.

'Jeez, you've finished already?' he said with arched eyebrows. I'd just done an hour's batting and catching, but he'd seen something. I might not have hit as many balls as usual; I could have been unconsciously hasty in heading back to the pavilion. Whatever it was, he hit the mark, because, as he told me when I eventually confirmed my retirement, 'We're pretty similar, aren't we?'

Game recognizes game at the highest levels of international sport. Jimmy had just bowled at 75 per cent for an hour. He never missed a length, and it looked as if it had taken nothing out of him. I knew that his ankle, shoulder and elbow hurt, but it looked so easy. Broady, standing beside me, murmured, 'If I did that, I'd be all over the place.'

He had to charge in, in every net session, to reach the standards he expected of himself. He knew that if he tried to be self-contained, in Jimmy's fashion, he would bowl poorly, and be difficult to deal with while he worked through the frustration. I can say that as a friend, because we have so much in common. We've made the most of any ability we've been given, but it has taken a lot of effort to do so.